

to open the sector to private sector participation since 2020. “Larger companies, which were primarily vendors to Isro, have now started warming up to the idea of investing in technology and making bigger bets in the space sector. So many of them now want to have access to making rockets, satellites, and other big projects,” Pawan Goenka, Chairman of IN-SPACe, tells *BT*. Following a recent IN-SPACe initiative, 23 companies expressed interest in manufacturing the Small Satellite Launch Vehicle (SSLV) developed by Isro to support the launch of satellite constellations into the Lower Earth Orbit (LEO) at affordable costs.

“Designing and producing critical systems locally will not only achieve self-reliance in strategic sectors like space but also provide huge employment and a significant multiplier to the domestic economy as work will flow down from the product OEMs to lower tiers of production,” says L&T’s Ramchandani.

Sreeram Ananthasayanam, Partner Consulting at Deloitte India, sees two cohorts of companies emerging: firms involved in upstream and downstream activities. The first will follow the Isro growth story to metamorphose into focusing on end-to-end capabilities or in segments like launch services and satellite or payload providers. “They have all the opportunity to evolve into mini-Isros.” But it is in the downstream segment that he sees far bigger potential. “Given India’s demographic dividend and its strengths in computers, advanced algorithms, and geospatial technologies, we see [it] taking a pole position in this segment.” Upstream activities involve satellite manufacturing, and launch services, while downstream activities encompass

POLICY PUSH

Beyond the policy framework, the government also provides funding support to firms in this space

TECHNOLOGY DEVELOPMENT FUND (TDF) SCHEME, MINISTRY OF DEFENCE

- ▶ MoD programme executed by Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) under the Make in India initiative
- ▶ It is an initiative to encourage MSMEs and start-ups to develop innovative defence technologies
- ▶ The scheme operates in grants-in-aid mode

ATAL INCUBATION CENTRE (AIC)

- ▶ AIC operates under the Atal Innovation Mission (AIM) Initiative
- ▶ Focus areas include UAVs, drones and surveillance equipment, aerospace tech, air taxis, space debris tracking and monitoring services and space education

IN-SPACE SEED FUND FOR SPACETECH START-UPS

- ▶ ₹1 crore (\$121,000) each to be provided to companies selected
- ▶ Package inclusive of mentorship, training and networking opportunities

